

Chapter 13

Electronic Documentation of Nigerian Indigenous Arts and Crafts for Historical Research Engagements and Tourism

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ABSTRACT

Indigenous arts, crafts, and culture are critical components of the world's diverse cultural heritage. Unfortunately, preserving this rich heritage remains challenging for most developing countries, especially with the increasing use of electronic media and the marginalisation of indigenous communities. This chapter discussed digital documentation strategies for Nigerian indigenous arts, crafts, and cultures to support future historical research engagements and tourism. It begins by examining indigenous arts, crafts, and cultures, such as stone carving, bronze and brass, weaving, pottery, etc. It tackled the importance and challenges of electronic documentation of these indigenous arts for historical research and tourism. Some case studies of successful electronic documentation of indigenous arts, crafts, and cultures in other societies were reviewed. Lessons were drawn from such previous efforts to shape future initiatives. It was concluded that documenting and preserving indigenous arts, crafts, and cultures is crucial for promoting and preserving cultural heritage.

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INTRODUCTION

Nigeria is home to a rich and diverse range of indigenous arts and crafts, reflecting the country's vibrant history and diverse ethnic groups. These art forms include traditional sculptures, textiles, pottery, basketry, beadwork, metalwork, and woodcarving, among others. Nigerian indigenous arts and crafts are often imbued with cultural and spiritual significance, telling the stories and histories of the people who create them. According to Osasona (2007), Nigeria's arts are also reflected in the indigenous design and architecture of its buildings across the northern, eastern, and southern parts of the country. Nigerian indigenous arts are significant to Nigeria's cultural heritage and are globally relevant. These art forms are an essential part of African cultural history and testify to the creativity and ingenuity of African artisans.

Nigerian crafts are intertwined with the country's spiritual philosophies and serve as valuable tools for promoting and preserving tourism. Nigeria's handicrafts encompass a variety of categories, including fabrics, ceramics, bronze, brass and iron works, fibres, handicrafts, ivory, jewellery, leatherwork, tie and dye, woodwork, pumpkin decorations, and more (Akintonde, 2013). Many of Nigeria's artistic works are displayed in museums worldwide. The utilisation of arts and crafts can catalyse sustainable development and industrial growth in an economy, as many people are not cognizant of the value, potential, and importance of Crafts in their daily lives (Iriwieri, 2009).

Despite the importance of Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts, there is a significant gap in the documentation and preservation of these art forms. Many of these art forms are at risk of being lost due to urbanisation, globalisation, and neglect (Kashim et al., 2013). Therefore, there is an urgent need for effective documentation strategies to preserve and promote Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts for future generations. The traditional practices of Nigeria are a valuable art historical resource that, if not studied in the present, may become inaccessible in the future due to the constantly changing nature of these practices. For Indigenous Knowledge (IK) to significantly promote sustainable development in African communities, it needs to be recorded, formalised, made available, exchanged, and spread widely (Tapfuma & Hoskin 2016). This is evidenced by many sculptures being lost, removed, or replaced while new ones are regularly created (Akintonde, 2013). The documentation and preservation of Nigerian indigenous arts are crucial in ensuring the continuity of these art forms and their cultural significance. The documentation of Nigerian indigenous arts and crafts allows for creation of an archive that can be used for future research and education. Researchers can study these arts to understand the historical, cultural, and artistic significance of these art forms. Preserving these arts ensures the longevity of the art forms and promotes cultural tourism, which can boost the economy of Nigeria and the African continent (Ezenagu, 2020). The exportation of Nigerian indigenous arts has the potential to foster cultural exchange and understanding between Nigeria and other countries.

Based on the available literature, the responsibility for preserving IK in Nigeria has been primarily handed over to the National Museum. Areo and Kalilu (2013) note that several Nigerian museums nationwide have established skill acquisition centres for tie and dye (Adire) production. This initiative, led by the national museums, has not only contributed to the growth of the textile industry but has also empowered numerous women and youth by providing them with employment opportunities. However, scholars have advocated for a shift in the preservation of IK by the realities of the 21st century, emphasising the use of Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) (Demssie et al., 2020). The rationale behind this perspective is that ICTs facilitate easy information retrieval, ensuring enhanced accessibility

to stored knowledge. Nevertheless, the literature suggests an evidence gap since there seem to be three schools of thought conceiving how IK should be preserved.

The first school advocates for using traditional methods to preserve indigenous knowledge (Okoye & Oni, 2017). The second school supports the application of modern approaches such as libraries and ICTs (Mdhluli et al., 2021). The ongoing debate between the two schools is such that neither of these methods has fully addressed the existing challenges in knowledge management (Zimu-Biyela, 2016). Given the complexity of IK preservation, the third school emerged, where authors have argued that a combination of both traditional and modern methods should be employed (Masenya, 2022; Mbilinyi & Mwabungulu, 2020; McGinnis et al., 2020). In line with this argument, this chapter proposes electronic documentation strategies for Nigerian indigenous arts and crafts that address the challenges of documenting these cultural resources. The chapter presents some case studies to demonstrate the effectiveness of the proposed approach. It highlights the importance of electronic documentation in preserving and promoting Nigerian indigenous arts and crafts. The chapter emphasises the potential impact of electronic documentation on historical research and tourism, contributing to the economic development of Nigeria.

CONCEPT OF ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION

Electronic documentation refers to recording and storing information, data, or documentation in electronic format. It uses digital technologies and tools to create, organise, store, retrieve, and manage documents and records. Electronic documentation can include various types of files, such as text documents, spreadsheets, presentations, images, videos, audio recordings, and more (Gilmore et al., 2018). Electronic documentation offers several advantages over traditional paper-based documentation, including easier storage, accessibility, searchability, and sharing of information (Gilmore et al., 2018). It allows for efficient organisation and retrieval of documents, enables collaborative work and remote access, reduces physical storage requirements, and supports the integration of multimedia elements into documentation. Examples of electronic documentation include word-processing documents, PDF files, email communications, databases, content management systems, and knowledge bases (Jordan et al., 2022). Electronic documentation plays a crucial role in various fields, such as business, healthcare, education, research, and government, facilitating the efficient management and preservation of information (Mukred et al., 2019).

In this chapter, the concept of electronic documentation involves digitising and preserving traditional knowledge and practices of indigenous communities using electronic tools and technologies. It aims to capture, record, and store indigenous knowledge in a digital format, making it accessible, searchable, and shareable. It involves using digital platforms, databases, multimedia tools, and other electronic means to record and document various aspects of indigenous knowledge, including language, folklore, medicinal practices, agricultural techniques, cultural traditions, and ecological wisdom. By digitising indigenous knowledge, electronic documentation helps overcome the challenges of oral transmission and the potential loss or degradation of traditional knowledge due to various factors like globalisation, urbanisation, and environmental changes (Carr et al., 2016; Eichler, 2021; Fernández-Llamazares & Cabeza, 2018). Electronic documentation of indigenous knowledge also facilitates knowledge exchange, collaboration, and engagement between indigenous communities, researchers, scholars, and policymakers (Fernández-Llamazares & Cabeza, 2018).

NIGERIAN INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS THAT ARE ELECTRONICALLY DOCUMENTABLE

This section discusses Nigeria's indigenous arts and crafts that can be electronically documented. These include the following:

Stone Carving/Sculpture

Stone carving has a long history in Nigeria, with evidence of early stone tools dating back thousands of years. The Nok people are renowned for their sophisticated stone sculptures, which often depict human and animal figures with intricate details and stylised features (Breunig et al., 2008). In particular, the southern regions of Nigeria are known for using stone in creating tall monoliths, narrow stone pillars typically featuring elaborate carvings and inscriptions. One notable example is the *Lechor Olikplikpo* in the Yala-Obubra community, Cross River State, Nigeria. *Lechor Olikplikpo* is a mysterious stone monolith that physically measures just an arm's length but comparatively longer than anyone that dares to measure his or her height with it; hence the submission that most Nigerian crafts and arts have spiritual significance. Many other stone monoliths in the Yala-Obubra community are yet to be documented electronically, such as the Ukpochi Playground monolith and the Omindom playground monolith, amongst others inside the river, seashores, in the community and forest of the area.

Another example is the Alok Ikom stone monoliths, which are believed to date back to the 17th century and are made from a local basalt known as "*akwasnshi/Atal*" (Nwankwo et al., 2018; Okwoche et al., 2021). They feature intricate carvings of human and animal figures and geometric designs. While they have some similarities, each stone is distinctive in its design and execution, much like a human fingerprint (Stout et al., 2008). Another example of stone carving in Nigeria is the Oshun Grove, a sacred site in Osogbo in southwestern Nigeria (Ijisakin, 2021; Shipley, 2017). The grove is home to intricately carved stone sculptures representing various deities and spiritual forces in the Yoruba religion. Examples of stone monoliths can be seen in Figure 1.

Figure 1. Stone monoliths



Bronze and Brass Craft

Bronze and brass crafting is a traditional art form still widely practised in Nigeria today. Various regions, such as Benin, Bida, and the southwest, are well-known for their skilled artisans. Although these indigenous works have been a part of Nigeria's artistic heritage for centuries, they gained international recognition when the Ife and Benin bronzes were discovered. Alongside these famous pieces, the Igbo-Ukwu archaeological finds have revealed an impressive collection of ancient and highly sophisticated works of art (McIntosh, 2022). The Igbo-Ukwu bronzes stand out for their elaborate and intricate designs, demonstrating remarkable symmetry and rivalling even the celebrated Ife works. These discoveries have greatly contributed to the appreciation and understanding of Nigeria's rich artistic heritage, attracting the attention of art enthusiasts worldwide. Examples of bronze and brass art are provided in Figure 2.

Wood Carving

Wood carving has been a prominent art form in Nigeria for centuries, with artisans producing various objects for various purposes (Sobowale et al., 2020). While places like Osogbo, Benin, Oyo, and Awka are often regarded as the centres of wood carving, skilled carvers have thrived throughout southern Nigeria (Sunday et al., 2022), creating figures for shrines, masks, portraits, representations of spirits, country, sky, sea, land, forest, fire, and thunder, as well as tools and ornaments that are still used today. Many of these intricate and exquisite works of art can be found in museums worldwide (Duncan & Wallach, 2019).

Figure 2. Bronze and brass craft



Over time, the art of wood carving in Nigeria has evolved (Ijisakin, 2019). Today, it is used for traditional and commercial purposes, such as producing furniture, bowls, doors, panels, and boxes, which are in high demand locally and internationally. The contemporary production of wooden furniture and other items in Nigeria reflects a blend of traditional techniques and modern design concepts. The demand for Nigerian wooden furniture has grown in recent years as consumers appreciate the beauty and durability of handmade items. From producing objects for traditional shrines to creating contemporary furniture, Nigerian wood carvers have demonstrated their exceptional skills and creativity in carving. Today, their works continue to be appreciated and admired by art enthusiasts worldwide. Figure 3 provides a pictorial depiction of some Nigerian arts made from wood carvings.

Ivory Carving

Ivory carving is a traditional art form in various parts of Nigeria, including Benin, Owo, Oyo, and traditional rulers' palaces. Ivory, derived from the tusks of elephants, has long been a precious material in Nigerian art and culture (Hornbeck, 2015). Ivory carvers in Nigeria create various intricate and decorative pieces, including necklaces, bracelets, hats, paper knives, cigar boxes, and other decorative items. In addition to their aesthetic value, ivory carvings have significant cultural and historical importance in Nigeria. These carvings are associated with traditional religious practices and rituals, serving as important spiritual and cultural heritage symbols. Ivory carvings are also often used as symbols of status and power, particularly in the palaces of traditional rulers. However, the practice of ivory carving in Nigeria has faced significant challenges in recent years due to international regulations on the trade of ivory (Aryal et al., 2018). Many countries have banned the trade of ivory to combat the illegal poaching of elephants and to protect endangered species. As a result, ivory carving in Nigeria has become increasingly rare, and many traditional carvers have had to find new materials to work with. Despite these challenges, the art of ivory carving in Nigeria remains an important part of the country's cultural heritage. An example of arts made through ivory carvings is represented in Figure 4.

Figure 3. Examples of wood carvings art



Figure 4. Ivory carvings



Weaving Craft

Weaving is an important craft in Nigeria with a rich history that dates back thousands of years. Some of Nigeria's most famous weaving traditions include the Aso-oke, Akwete, and Adire (Ojo, 2007; Seidu et al., 2022). Aso-oke is a handwoven cloth made by the Yoruba people, primarily for special occasions such as weddings, festivals, and funerals. The fabric is made from locally grown cotton and comes in various colours and designs. It is characterised by its stiffness and durability, making it a popular material for clothing, bags, and hats. The Akwete cloth, on the other hand, is woven by the Igbo people using a traditional horizontal loom. Made from locally grown cotton, it features intricate patterns and designs unique to the region. The Akwete cloth is often used for clothing, wrappers, and ceremonial purposes. Another popular weaving tradition in Nigeria is Adire, a resist-dyed cloth made by the Yoruba people (Areo & Kalilu, 2013; Renne, 2020). The cloth is made by tying, stitching, or folding the fabric before applying the dye, resulting in a unique pattern. Examples of wrappers produced from the adire cloth are shown in Figure 5.

In addition to these weaving traditions, many other weaving styles and techniques are practised across Nigeria, including raffia, straw, and other natural fibres. For instance, the Ndam and Esighi materials are specially produced by the Efik people in Cross River State, from Palm trees to weave beautiful and colourful attires worn by different *Ekpe* and masquerades. Similarly, the Yala-Obubra community in Cross River State has a special plant called "*Akwubleh*", which looks like the sugar cane plant but grows taller and inedible. The leaves of this plant are harvested, and sleeping mats are woven from it. Similarly, the

Figure 5. Examples of Adire wrappers



stems of the *Akwubleh* plant are cut and smashed or pounded into tiny strips, which can be used to weave clothes, usually worn by masquerades. Cane weaving is another traditional craft in Nigeria, with a long history of producing functional and decorative items (Okonkwo et al., 2016). The craft involves weaving dried cane or bamboo strips into baskets, mats, furniture, and other household items. Cane weaving is still practised in many parts of Nigeria, and some artisans have adapted the craft to create contemporary designs for a global market. Figure 6 is a pictorial representation of craftwork made from cane weaving. A sample of products made from bead weaving in Nigeria is displayed in Figure 7.

Pottery

Pottery-making in Nigeria is a traditional practice predominantly carried out by women (Peters, 2021). Nigerian potters create both functional and decorative pieces using various techniques and materials. The most common types of pottery in Nigeria are earthenware (Matshameko et al., 2022) and stoneware (Uriah et al., 2014). Earthenware is made by forming clay into a desired shape, drying it in the sun, and then firing it in a kiln. Earthenware pottery is known for its rough texture and is often used for cooking and storage. It is commonly found in the northern part of Nigeria. On the other hand, stoneware is made by adding sand or other materials to the clay, making it more durable and heat-resistant. Stoneware pottery is smoother and more refined than earthenware and is often used for decorative purposes. It is commonly found in the southern part of Nigeria. Nigerian pottery is known for its intricate designs and patterns, often inspired by nature, traditional symbols, and cultural heritage. Some potters also incorporate other materials, such as cowrie shells, beads, and metal, into their designs. Pottery-making is often a family tradition passed down from generation to generation. In some communities, pottery-making is considered sacred art to create ritual objects and vessels for traditional ceremonies. Today, Nigerian

Figure 6. Products of cane weaving in Nigeria



Figure 7. Products made from beads in Nigeria



pottery is sold in markets throughout the country and exported to other parts of the world. Samples of clay products in Nigeria are displayed in Figure 8.

Hides, Skins, and Leatherwork

Hides, skins, and leatherwork have long been important to Nigerian art and culture (Oladejo, 2019; Siyanbola et al., 2012). The production of leather goods has traditionally been male-dominated, with many

Figure 8. Clay pots made in Nigeria

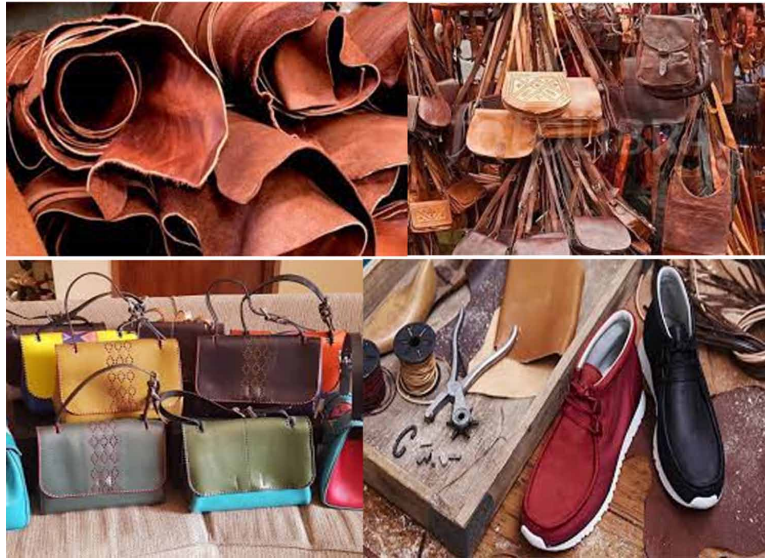


artisans passing their skills down through generations. The leather is often sourced from domesticated animals, such as cows and goats, and is carefully treated and processed to create a durable material. In northern Nigeria, the Hausa people are particularly renowned for their leatherwork (Noah & Çağnan, 2021). They use traditional techniques to create various items, including bags, belts, sandals, and armour. The leather is often dyed using natural pigments, such as indigo and henna, and is then embellished with intricate designs and patterns. In addition to leatherwork, hides and skins are also used to produce textiles. The Fulani people of Nigeria are also known for using hides and skins in their artwork (Abubakar, 2021). They create intricate carvings and relief sculptures using a combination of leather and wood, often depicting scenes from everyday life or religious and cultural symbols. Overall, hides, skins, and leatherwork are an important part of Nigeria's rich artistic heritage, with artisans continuing to produce high-quality pieces using traditional techniques and materials. Figure 9 shows some artwork produced from skins, hides and leather.

Tie and Dye

Tie-dye is a traditional fabric art in Nigeria that involves tying, folding, twisting, or pleating fabric and then applying dye to create patterns and designs. This technique is widely used in traditional Nigerian clothing, such as the Buba and the Gele. It has also been adopted by contemporary fashion designers who use it to create vibrant and unique clothing designs. This technique is called Adire, a Yoruba word meaning "tie and dye." Adire is a popular textile craft in southwestern Nigeria, particularly in Abeokuta in Ogun State. Traditionally, tie-dye was done using indigo dyes (Maiwada et al., 2012) made from indigo plants grown in Nigeria. The indigo dye was mixed with cassava paste, which acted as a resist and prevented the dye from spreading to certain areas of the fabric. This allowed the artist to create intricate patterns and designs on the fabric. Today, tie and dye artists in Nigeria use a variety of dyes, including synthetic dyes, to create vibrant and colourful fabrics. They also use a range of local materials, such as Adire Eleko (Areo & Kalilu, 2013; Renne, 2020), a type of cassava starch), cowries (a type of shell), and local leaves such as moringa (Adesina et al., 2021), to create unique patterns and designs. Tie-dye

Figure 9. Bags and shoes produced using animal skins and leather



creates various fabrics, including clothing, bedspreads, tablecloths, and wall hangings. It is a popular art form celebrated in Nigeria and worldwide for its vibrant colours, intricate designs, and cultural significance. In recent years, there has been a resurgence of interest in traditional tie and dye techniques, with many young artists incorporating these techniques into their work and experimenting with new materials and designs.

IMPORTANCE OF ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION OF INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS FOR HISTORICAL RESEARCH AND TOURISM

This section articulates the vital role of electronic documentation in preserving and promoting indigenous Arts and Crafts for historical research and tourism. By capturing and sharing these cultural expressions, electronic platforms ensure their longevity, accessibility, and appreciation, fostering cross-cultural understanding, supporting cultural revitalisation, and promoting responsible tourism practices. The following are some importance of electronically documenting indigenous Arts and Crafts:

Increased Information

Electronic documentation provides historians access to a wealth of information that may not have been available. The internet, for example, has made it possible to access a vast amount of historical material from around the world, making it easier for researchers to conduct comprehensive and interdisciplinary studies. Online databases, digital libraries, and archives provide researchers with access to rare or out-of-print books, manuscripts, and primary sources that they may not have been able to access previously. This is important for historical research as it allows researchers to understand the past better, leading to more accurate and insightful interpretations. For tourism, increased access to historical information can

enhance the visitor experience by providing more detailed and accurate information about historical sites and landmarks. For example, imaging technology can be used to create virtual tours or exhibits, providing visitors with access to historical information that they may not have been able to access otherwise.

Preservation

Preservation is one of the most important benefits of electronic historical artefact documentation. With digital technology, it is possible to create high-quality digital copies of artefacts, which can be stored in a secure digital archive. This allows the original artefacts to be preserved and protected from wear and tear caused by handling or exposure to the elements. In addition, electronic documentation provides an efficient way to monitor the condition of artefacts over time. It allows researchers to compare digital copies created at different times to detect changes in condition or deterioration. For tourism, preserving historical artefacts through electronic documentation enables the creation of virtual exhibits or displays. This can be especially useful for tourists who may not have the opportunity to visit physical museums or historical sites. From a historical research perspective, preserving artefacts through electronic documentation is crucial for ensuring they remain available for future generations to study and learn from. This is especially important given the limited lifespan of many artefacts, which can deteriorate or become lost or damaged due to natural disasters or human conflict. With electronic documentation, historians can be assured that important historical artefacts are preserved for future research and understanding.

Accessibility

Electronic documentation provides unprecedented access to historical information, making it easier for people to research and learn about historical sites and landmarks. With the vast amount of historical material available online, historians can access a wealth of information that may not have been available, enabling them to conduct more thorough and detailed analyses of historical events and phenomena. For tourism, this means that potential visitors can research and plan their trips from anywhere in the world, even if they cannot visit the location physically. This enables them to learn about the historical significance of the site or landmark, which can increase their interest in visiting and promote tourism. This, in turn, can have significant economic benefits for the surrounding community. For historical research, electronic documentation enables scholars to access historical information from anywhere in the world, removing the physical barriers that may have hindered research in the past. This allows historians to research and collaborate with colleagues regardless of location, leading to more comprehensive and interdisciplinary studies. Furthermore, the results of studies can be disseminated more widely, reaching a broader audience and facilitating a greater understanding and appreciation of historical events and phenomena.

Organisation

Electronic documentation enables historical information to be organised in a way that may not have been possible with physical records. This organisation can help make historical information more accessible to both tourists and historians. For tourism, organised information enables visitors to find information quickly and easily about historical sites and artefacts, enhancing their experience and allowing them to make the most of their visit. This can increase interest in historical sites and landmarks, promoting tour-

ism and benefiting the surrounding community. Organised historical information can help researchers quickly find and analyse information, leading to more efficient and effective research. This is particularly important for large-scale studies, where the sheer volume of information can be overwhelming.

Collaboration

Electronic documentation can efficiently allow researchers and institutions to collaborate on historical research projects. Researchers can easily share resources using electronic communication tools, including data, images, and manuscripts. This facilitates interdisciplinary research, allowing researchers from different fields to contribute their expertise and perspectives to a project. Collaboration can lead to new insights into history and culture, as well as new research methods that are more efficient and effective. Collaborative research can also help identify new areas of interest, leading to the development of new tourism opportunities. For example, collaborative research on the history of a particular region might reveal a previously unknown cultural practice that can be incorporated into a tourism package. For tourism, collaborative research can lead to more accurate and interesting information about historical sites and artefacts. This can enhance the visitor experience by providing a more comprehensive understanding of the history and culture of a particular location. Furthermore, collaboration can foster partnerships between researchers and tourism stakeholders, such as museums, heritage sites, and local communities (Owan et al., 2023). This can lead to the development of joint projects and initiatives that benefit both the tourism industry and historical research.

Tourism Promotion

Electronic documentation can provide a platform for promoting tourism by showcasing historical sites and landmarks. Digital media and online platforms such as social media, blogs, and websites can attract potential visitors to historical sites and landmarks by providing detailed information and visuals about the sites. This can create interest and generate buzz around the sites, increasing tourism and economic benefits for the surrounding community. For example, electronic documentation can be used to create virtual tours and exhibits of historical sites, providing visitors with an immersive and interactive experience that can enhance their understanding and appreciation of the history and culture of the location. This can be especially important for visitors who cannot physically visit the location due to physical or financial constraints. Promoting tourism for historical research can increase funding and support for preservation and research projects, which can benefit researchers and the wider community. By generating interest and awareness about historical sites and artefacts, researchers can attract the attention of potential donors, sponsors, and supporters interested in preserving and promoting cultural heritage.

FACTORS THAT IMPEDE THE ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION OF NIGERIAN INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS

The following are the factors that affect the documentation of Nigerian indigenous arts and crafts in electronic databases.

Historical Factors

The documentation of Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts faces several historical factors that impede its progress. One of the main factors is the oral nature of many of these cultures, where traditions and knowledge are passed down from generation to generation through storytelling, dance, and music. This means that much of these communities' history and cultural knowledge may not have been documented in written form and can be lost over time. Additionally, colonialism and the slave trade have significantly impacted the documentation of Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts. Many cultural artefacts were taken away during the slave trade, while colonialism disrupted traditional social structures and cultural practices. This led to a loss of cultural heritage and knowledge, making it more difficult to document and understand these cultures.

Another factor is the lack of resources and infrastructure to document and preserve these cultural artefacts. Many communities lack access to modern technology or trained personnel to properly document their culture and artefacts (Istvandity, 2021; Rakemane & Mosweu, 2021). This can lead to poor documentation, inaccurate preservation, and even loss of cultural heritage. Moreover, political instability and conflicts have also impeded indigenous arts, crafts, and culture documentation. Nigeria has experienced various forms of political unrest, including civil wars and insurgencies, which have destroyed cultural artefacts and displacement of communities. Lastly, the globalisation of culture and the dominance of Western culture have also impacted the documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts. Many communities are pressured to conform to Western standards and abandon their traditional practices, leading to a loss of cultural heritage and knowledge.

Technological and Logistical Factors

Technology and logistics have also impeded Nigerian indigenous arts, crafts, and culture documentation. One of the major technological challenges is the lack of access to modern recording equipment and software. Many remote communities where these arts and crafts are practised lack the necessary infrastructure to support the use of technology, making it difficult to document their practices. Additionally, the cost of such equipment is often prohibitive, making it difficult for researchers to access them. Logistical challenges also play a significant role in impeding the documentation of indigenous arts and cultures. Nigeria is a vast and diverse country with many ethnic groups and languages. Researchers often face difficulty accessing remote locations due to poor transportation networks, rugged terrain, and lack of infrastructure. This makes it difficult to document the cultural practices of these communities, which are often only passed down orally and through practical demonstrations.

Another logistical challenge is the language barrier. Nigeria has over 500 languages, making it difficult for researchers to communicate with members of these communities. This is particularly problematic when attempting to document cultural practices only passed down through oral traditions. Valuable cultural knowledge may be lost or misrepresented without proper translation and interpretation. Furthermore, cultural and religious sensitivities often exist around the documentation of indigenous arts and cultures. Some communities may view the documentation of their practices as a violation of their cultural heritage, leading to resistance or reluctance to share their knowledge with outsiders. This can make it difficult for researchers to gain the trust of these communities and access the information they need.

Socio-Cultural Factors

Socio-cultural factors can also impede the documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts in Nigeria. The first factor is the lack of interest and appreciation for indigenous arts and crafts. Many people value Western art and crafts over traditional ones, leading to a lack of demand for indigenous artworks. As a result, there is a limited market for indigenous arts, and artists may not see the need to document their work or its cultural significance. Secondly, some cultural beliefs and practices restrict the documentation of certain artworks and cultural practices. For instance, some Nigerian cultures believe certain artistic works and practices are sacred and should not be shared or documented with outsiders. This can make it difficult for researchers to access certain cultural artefacts and practices, hindering documentation.

Thirdly, the social status of indigenous artisans can also be a factor. Many indigenous artisans in Nigeria are from lower socioeconomic backgrounds, and their work is not always valued or recognised. This can lead to a lack of resources and infrastructure for documenting their work and limited access to technology and training in documentation techniques. Lastly, the lack of institutional support and funding for documenting indigenous arts and crafts poses a challenge. Many institutions and organisations may prioritise Western art and culture over indigenous ones, leading to a lack of funding and support for documenting indigenous cultural practices. This can hinder the efforts of researchers and indigenous artisans in documenting their work and culture.

Economic Factors

Economic factors can also impede the documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts. Many indigenous communities often live in poverty and lack the resources to invest in documenting their cultural practices. As a result, documenting their cultural heritage may not be a priority, and they may lack the funds to purchase equipment or pay for the services of professional documentarians. Furthermore, there may be limited economic opportunities for commercialising indigenous arts and crafts, which may discourage the investment of resources in their documentation. The lack of economic incentives for documenting indigenous arts and crafts can also lead to a lack of interest from private companies and government agencies in funding documentation efforts. Additionally, economic factors can contribute to exploiting indigenous cultures and resources. In some cases, individuals or companies may seek to profit from commercialising indigenous cultural practices without the consent or benefit of the communities in question. This can lead to a reluctance among indigenous communities to share their cultural practices and knowledge, as they may fear exploitation or cultural appropriation.

Political Factors

Political factors can also impede the documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts in Nigeria. One major factor is government policy, which can hinder documentation efforts. Government policies may not prioritise the documentation of indigenous arts and cultures, leading to a lack of resources and funding for documentation efforts. Additionally, political instability and conflict in certain regions of Nigeria can make it difficult for researchers to access and document indigenous cultures. Another political factor is censorship and control of information. In some cases, governments may limit or control the documentation of indigenous cultures due to cultural or political sensitivities. This can result in a lack

of information available to researchers and the wider public, hindering efforts to document and preserve indigenous cultures. Furthermore, the lack of government recognition and support for traditional art forms and cultural practices can lead to declining interest and investment in documenting indigenous arts and cultures. This can result in a lack of resources and infrastructure to support documentation efforts, making it difficult for researchers to collect and preserve information.

Religious Factors

Religion can also be a factor that impedes the documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts in Nigeria. Some indigenous cultures and art forms are closely tied to religious practices and beliefs. These cultures and art forms may not be readily shared with outsiders, as they are considered sacred and restricted to members of a particular religious group. In some cases, religious beliefs may also destroy or alter indigenous art and cultural artefacts. Certain religious groups may view certain art forms or practices as pagan or idolatrous and seek to eliminate or modify them. For instance, the penetration of Christianity into Africa and Nigeria, in particular, has altered various traditional practices. In some cases, pastors and church ministers are observed burning indigenous arts and crafts, and abolishing certain cultural practices, terming them “fetish” or “unholy”. As a result, some indigenous people have stopped practising or teaching traditional arts and crafts, leading to a decline in the transmission of knowledge about these practices, affecting documentation efforts.

Furthermore, Christian missions and missionaries often prioritise the documentation and preservation of Christian arts and artefacts over indigenous ones, which can further marginalise indigenous cultures and contribute to the loss of traditional knowledge. Religious conflicts and tensions complicate documenting and preserving indigenous arts and cultures. Nigeria has experienced several religious conflicts, with some destroying cultural artefacts. This can make it difficult for historians and researchers to access and study these artefacts, as they may have been destroyed or lost.

STRATEGIES FOR ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION OF NIGERIAN INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS

This section discusses the strategies for electronically documenting Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts.

Creation of a Digital Repository

Creating a digital repository for Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts is an essential strategy for electronic documentation. This repository can be a central hub for storing and sharing digital copies of artefacts, photographs, audio recordings, and other relevant materials. For instance, the Igbo-Ukwu bronze artefacts, a collection of brass objects discovered in Igbo-Ukwu, can be preserved and accessible to scholars and the general public through this strategy.

Digitisation of Physical Archives and Manuscripts

The digitisation of physical archives and manuscripts is another key strategy for electronic documentation. This will help to preserve these materials and make them more accessible to researchers, scholars,

and the public. For example, digitising manuscripts and archives related to the Nok Terracotta can aid in preserving and sharing information about the culture and art of the Nok people.

Development of Multimedia Resources

The development of multimedia resources, such as videos, podcasts, and interactive exhibits, can help to engage a wider audience and promote interest in Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts. These resources, including social media and the digital repository, can be shared online. For example, a video showcasing the weaving process of the Akwete cloth of the Igbo people can be developed to help promote the art and craft to a wider audience.

Collaboration With Local Communities

Collaboration with local communities is crucial for the successful electronic documentation of Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts. This collaboration can help ensure that cultural practices and traditions are accurately represented, and that the community has a stake in preserving and promoting its heritage. For example, collaborations with the Efik or Ibibio communities can aid in preserving the Ekpe Masquerade, a prominent cultural practice in the region.

Training of Local Experts

The training of local experts in electronic documentation techniques and technologies can help to build capacity and ensure the sustainability of the documentation efforts. This can involve training in digital photography, audio recording, metadata management, and other relevant skills. For instance, training in digital photography, audio recording, metadata management, and other relevant skills can be provided to the community members with traditional knowledge of stone carving/sculpturing in Cross River State.

Promotion of Electronic Documentation Efforts

Promoting electronic documentation through targeted marketing campaigns can raise awareness and generate interest among potential stakeholders, including tourists, scholars, and funding agencies. This can involve the development of a website or social media presence for the digital repository, as well as outreach to relevant organisations and institutions.

Integration With Education

Integration of electronic documentation efforts with education can ensure that future generations are aware of and engaged with Nigerian indigenous Arts and Crafts. This can involve the development of educational materials and resources, such as online courses, workshops, and classroom materials, that incorporate the digital repository and multimedia resources. For instance, this strategy can teach the Yoruba people's history and traditional use of Aso Oke cloth in Nigerian schools.

CASE STUDIES OF SUCCESSFUL ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION OF INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS

This section reviews successful projects documenting indigenous arts, crafts or cultures in different parts of the world. The first case study is the Museum of Anthropology at the University of British Columbia (MOA) has a digital collection of Northwest Coast Indigenous art that includes over 12,000 objects, photographs, and archival documents (Kramer, 2013). The strengths of this project include the extensive scope of the collection, the quality of the digital images, and the user-friendly online platform. The digital collection provides access to artefacts that may be difficult for researchers and community members to access in person due to geographic and cultural barriers.

The Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of the American Indian (NMAI) in the United States is another example of successful electronic documentation of indigenous Arts and Crafts. The NMAI has created an extensive digital repository of materials related to the Native peoples of the Americas, including images, audio recordings, and videos (Drumheller & Kaminitz, 1994; Rosoff, 2005). One strength of the NMAI's digital repository is its focus on community engagement and collaboration. The museum has worked closely with Native communities to ensure that their cultural traditions and practices are accurately represented in the digital collection. The NMAI has also provided training to Native community members on using the digital tools and technologies needed for documentation and preservation. Another strength of the NMAI's electronic documentation efforts is the development of multimedia resources. The museum has produced various videos, podcasts, and interactive exhibits that help engage a wider audience and promote interest in Native American cultures. These resources are available on the museum's website, as well as on social media platforms.

One notable example of a successful electronic documentation project for indigenous Arts and Crafts is the "Digital Library of the National Museum of Anthropology" in Mexico City. The National Museum of Anthropology is one of the world's most important museums dedicated to Mexico's history and anthropology. It contains many artefacts, including many examples of indigenous art and craftwork (Lau, 2009). One of the strengths of this project is the high-quality digital reproductions of the artefacts, which allow users to examine the items in detail and appreciate their intricate details. The digital library also includes detailed descriptions and contextual information about each item, providing users with important cultural and historical context. Another strength of the project is its accessibility, with the digital library available online for free to anyone with an internet connection. This has helped promote interest in Mexican indigenous Arts and Crafts locally and internationally.

The British Museum in London, United Kingdom, has implemented electronic documentation strategies to preserve and promote the cultural heritage of indigenous communities across the world (Ballard et al., 2017; Harris, 2015). They have a digital repository that includes thousands of photographs, videos, and other digital resources, as well as multimedia exhibits and educational materials. The British Museum's electronic documentation strategies have several strengths. First, their digital repository contains many materials, making it a valuable resource for researchers, scholars, and the general public. Second, the multimedia exhibits and educational materials help to engage a wider audience and promote interest in indigenous cultures (Taylor & Gibson, 2017). Third, the collaboration with local communities, as evidenced by the inclusion of contemporary voices and perspectives in the materials, ensures that the cultural heritage is accurately represented and respects the community's stake in their heritage (Srinivasan et al., 2009).

The National Museum of Mali has implemented electronic documentation strategies to preserve and promote the cultural heritage of indigenous communities in Mali. Their digital repository includes photographs, videos, other resources, multimedia exhibits, and educational materials. The National Museum of Mali's implementation of electronic documentation strategies is a strength because it allows for preserving and promoting indigenous cultures in Mali. The digital repository allows for wider access to cultural resources, which can help increase awareness and understanding of these communities (Arnoldi et al., 2021; Konaré, 1981). The multimedia exhibits and educational materials can also help engage a wider audience and promote interest in Mali's indigenous cultures. One potential weakness of the project may be the accessibility of the digital resources to the local communities themselves (Arnoldi, 2006). While it is important to have a wider reach, it is also crucial that local communities have access to their cultural heritage.

LESSONS LEARNED FROM PREVIOUS ELECTRONIC DOCUMENTATION EFFORTS OF INDIGENOUS ARTS AND CRAFTS

Based on the weaknesses identified in earlier attempts to document indigenous Arts and Crafts electronically, this chapter can derive the following lessons learned and recommendations for future efforts in Nigeria:

Community Involvement

Many past initiatives lacked the involvement of Indigenous communities in creating and managing digital collections, resulting in a lack of cultural sensitivity and inclusivity. This lack of community involvement meant cultural materials were often collected without proper consultation or permission, leading to distrust and frustration among Indigenous communities. Future initiatives should prioritise community involvement in creating and managing digital collections, ensuring that Indigenous communities are consulted and involved in all aspects of the collection process. This can be achieved by establishing partnerships with local organisations and community leaders and involving community members in training and capacity-building activities.

Cultural Sensitivity

Some past efforts neglected indigenous communities' cultural practices and beliefs, leading to incomplete or inaccurate documentation of cultural objects. This resulted in misrepresentations of cultural materials, which indigenous communities viewed as offensive or disrespectful. As a result, many indigenous communities hesitated to participate in future initiatives. Future efforts should prioritise cultural sensitivity in the documentation process to respect Indigenous communities' cultural practices and beliefs. This can be achieved by involving Indigenous communities in the documentation process, providing adequate training and support to researchers and project teams, and creating culturally-sensitive metadata and descriptive information.

Accessibility

Previous initiatives often faced challenges in accessibility, with collections being available only in certain languages or through limited platforms. This limited access made it difficult for Indigenous

communities to access and use digital collections, reducing the potential impact of the collections. To ensure digital collections are accessible to all, future initiatives should prioritise accessibility by making collections available in various Nigerian languages and accessible through multiple platforms, including mobile phones. This can be achieved by partnering with local technology companies and telecommunication providers and providing training and resources to community members on how to access and use digital collections.

Sustainability

Many earlier initiatives were not sustainable, resulting in outdated or inaccessible collections due to insufficient funding or resources. Digital collections became obsolete over time, with limited capacity for future updates or maintenance. This undermined the potential long-term impact of digital collections. To ensure the long-term viability of digital collections, subsequent attempts should prioritise sustainability by establishing partnerships with local universities and research institutions and securing adequate funding for the ongoing maintenance and development of digital collections.

Capacity Building

Previous initiatives often failed to build capacity within Indigenous communities to manage and curate digital collections, leading to a lack of ownership and control over cultural materials. This lack of ownership and control meant that Indigenous communities often felt excluded from the digital collection process, reducing the potential impact of digital collections on these communities. Therefore, future initiatives should prioritise capacity building by providing training and resources tailored to the needs and context of different communities to ensure Indigenous communities are equipped to manage and curate digital collections. This can be achieved by establishing partnerships with local organisations and community leaders.

Digital Preservation

Past initiatives lacked comprehensive digital preservation policies, leading to the loss or degradation of digital collections over time. This meant that many collections were lost or damaged due to insufficient backup or storage mechanisms, undermining the potential impact of digital collections on future generations. Thus, subsequent attempts to document indigenous Arts and Crafts by nations such as Nigeria should prioritise comprehensive digital preservation policies by adopting established digital preservation standards and best practices and partnering with local technology companies and research institutions to prevent the loss or degradation of digital collections and ensure that digital collections are properly maintained and preserved.

Evaluation and Assessment

Many past efforts failed to evaluate the impact of digital collections on Indigenous communities and broader audiences. This lack of evaluation made it difficult to determine the effectiveness of digital collections and identify areas for improvement. As a result, many digital collections failed to meet their intended objectives or have the desired impact on their intended audiences. To regularly assess and

monitor the impact of digital collections, future efforts should prioritise evaluation and assessment by developing frameworks tailored to the needs and context of different communities and partnering with local organisations and research institutions to collect and analyse data on the impact of digital collections.

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

In conclusion, documenting and preserving indigenous Arts and Crafts is crucial for promoting and preserving cultural heritage. Electronic documentation offers immense potential to achieve this objective but requires careful planning and implementation. The lessons learned from previous electronic documentation efforts of indigenous Arts and Crafts provide useful insights and recommendations for future initiatives in Nigeria and other nations. Community involvement, cultural sensitivity, accessibility, sustainability, funding, capacity building, digital preservation, and evaluation and assessment are all critical factors to consider in future efforts. By prioritising these factors, we can ensure that digital collections of indigenous Arts and Crafts are comprehensive, accessible, and sustainable, positively impacting Indigenous communities and broader audiences for years to come. Moreover, these initiatives can foster trust, collaboration, and co-creation with Indigenous communities, ultimately promoting cultural preservation, revitalisation, and empowerment. The digital collections resulting from these initiatives can be used for research, education, and cultural promotion, benefiting not only Indigenous communities but also broader audiences interested in learning about the diverse cultural heritage of Nigeria.

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KEY TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

Cultural Heritage: The tangible and intangible products of a community's cultural and artistic traditions inherited from previous generations and transmitted to future generations.

Digital Preservation: The process of ensuring that digital content is stored, maintained, and usable over time, often involving measures to prevent data loss or degradation.

Indigenous Knowledge: Knowledge and practices unique to a particular culture or community often passed down through generations, reflecting a deep understanding of the natural environment and its resources.

Metadata Management Software: Software designed to facilitate the creation, management, and retrieval of metadata for digital objects.

Open Access: The practice of making digital resources freely available to the public, often through online platforms, without restrictions on use or reuse.